A Lynching in Stereoscope

By Stephanie Dickinson

I lift the stereoscope to my face. True old-timer amusement. The card photograph is of a bare-foot corpse. Hanging from a bridge, a pretty woman in a calico dress. I can see the ripples in the brown river, and almost her the sluggish gurgling. A postcard. Etched into the corner "Copyright 1934 – Arkansas – unmailable." At the edge of the photograph is another hanging body, smaller then the woman's. Badly burned, too burned to tell what sex it is. I breathe deeply. Take the card out of the stereoscope. Who is she? Why did they hang her on this afternoon?

INTRODUCTION

Let the story of Ciz and Alp (last name unknown) be told . . . Sometimes lynchings became mass spectacles with a circus atmosphere. Children often attended these public lynchings, and it was common for postcards to be sold. These postcards became popular enough to be an embarrassment to the government, and the postmaster officially banned them in 1908. However, the lynching postcards continued to exist through the 1930's.

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Records exist from Waco, Texas in 1916 of a postcard showing the burned body of Jesse Washington,. Washington was a 17-year-old retarded farmhand who had confessed to raping and killing a white woman. He was castrated, mutilated, and burned alive by a cheering mob that included the mayor and the chief of police. A tree supported the iron chain that lifted him above the fire. . . Wailing, the boy attempted to climb up the skillet hot chain. For this, the men cut off his fingers. On the back of the postcard, was a hand written note: "This is the barbeque we had last night."

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Today is soap-making day. The ninety degrees are crowding me as I push my head through the dress neck, and pull the comb through my wild hair that needs three hands to tie it back. I press the tin mirror close to my face and hunt for the light in my eyes, like once I searched for my son's father. I was thirteen then. Now I'm twenty-five and I stand four feet eight inches tall.

"Alp, rise and shine, my sweet potato pie." I sing to my son still asleep behind the curtain that divides the room.

Suddenly the hairs stiffen on my upper lip. The eyes in the back of my head see the dog on the stop. A

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white bloodhound. . . panting. A scream knots my throat. "Shoo," I say to the bloodhound. "What do you want with me?" When I turn to the screen the dog is gone, and Alp is rubbing his sleep face. He's a big boy, almost six feet tall and just going on twelve. Sweet natured with dimples . . . give him a white peach and he's happy for a week.

And then [I] see fifty townspeople walking in the stun through the black walnuts and buckthorn and crabapples. What do they want? They must be going after someone. Maybe one of the croppers stole something. "What can I do for you?" I call out. I recognize Sheriff Garner. His deputies have regular redbone hounds tugging at leashes. The redbones sniff their way . . . "We've found the dog," the square-headed deputy shouts. "Know who this her dog belongs to? R.E. Lee Wilson."

My blood ices. Mr. R.E. owns the air I'm breathing. Sheriff Garner walks toward me, rocking the upper part of his body. "This dog was trailing the

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boy who molested a nine-year-old girl. Happened this morning!"

"My boy's been with me all day. The folks around here can tell you." Alp steps out of the kitchen and three or four town men in suspenders and straw hats hustle him over to where I am. "Listen. Whatever he done, whatever you say he done, I did it. He didn't do anything."

"We're going to make us a trial. This animal took down his pants in front of a nine-year-old girl."

They dunk Alp's hand into the scalding soap. His scream rises to the treetops. First time he ever pees himself since he was a baby.

Names fly. Killers, castrated pigs, dirt shack dung, coons.

The steel-spectacled deputy hits my boy in the mouth. Alp shudders like a dog shaking off ditch water. Men push through the deputies. Men push through the deputies, a bunch of cotton shirts, old-fashioned neck-pieces. "Make the bastard talk about what he did to R.E. Lee's girl!"

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I jump between them and Alp, cover him with as much of me as I can muster. A boot picks itself up, hell banging my hip. The flat of another lands solid in the small of my back.

"Leave the woman be," Sheriff Garner bellows.

A female cries, "Cleanse the sin from R.E. Lee's child."

I crawl to Sheriff Garner's pant leg. "Let my son be. I swear he's good." My heart's rasping. "My boy's been with me all day."

The spectacled deputy takes off his belt. "Lets tend to the boy." One after another the men come, taking turns whipping. None hide their faces. My son's eyes swell shut. At least he's saved from seeing. The deputy dunks my son's other hand in the soap. This time Alp's scream digs a hole in the ground.

"Let's take them to the river." They push me after my son. Red water's leaking from Alps forearms where the skin is ripped. I scream. They ball a handkerchief and stick it in my mouth. Let me go with him. He's afraid of when the weather changes too many

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times in one day, he's afraid of ladders and birds. They hold me back. They tie him up and pile on the kindling. Fifty, now there's a hundred streaming past me. Laughers, jerkers, spitters. They crash into the woods. A newspaperman takes out his tablet. "We're just swatting a few mosquitoes. That's not news."

I'm not afraid anymore. They're burning my son. I hear his screams. They must pull him from the fire to savor him. For thirty minutes my baby howls. Alp, it's your mama, honey love. You're named Alp after those cold tall mountains far away. Go there in your mind. They burn him slow.

I feel a yank as they cord my wrists behind my back. Someone rips my apron. Let's go swimming, sweetheart." They walk me to the bridge. Last sun ripples in the sluggish current. This is the river Alp was baptized in.

My heart is gone when they push a charred thing past me in a wheelbarrow. The thing has no legs. It raises up on its haunches, reaching out, no hands on the ends of it blackened wrists.

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A man with a whiskey nose croaks, " I'm going to write the boys down there in Delight. Tell them about the barbeque we had this afternoon."

Townspeople crowd both sides of the river. There's a bunch behind me. Someone is playing an accordion. Someone is selling rock candy.

"Make way, make way, R.E. Wilson's on his way." And then I see the man who owns the dirt where they make me set my feet.

"This is the boy who done it, R.E." They push the blackened thing in the wheelbarrow at him. A burnt offering. He has a golden boy and girl with him, a twin set.

Devil is the name I give the one who puts a rope around my neck. A man ties my torn apron. For an instant I think kindness. Then his hands fill my pockets with pebbles. Alp, they're going to hand you too, even if you're already dead. A stone hits me in the stomach, then a stick. I raise my face, even as a peach pit hits my forehead. A rope has been tied to a joint, the noose end coils in the dust.

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My ashy son hangs over the water; my son who has no hands is buried in the air on the summer vines. The photographer is moving closer, his camera like a box lunch at an ice cream social. "Let's see you do a jig, Ciz." Is it true when they take a photograph at the moment of death, that's where your soul stays?

I drop. Ripples of heat rise from the trees. I'm listening to the leaves turn over, tinkling, showing off their silver undersides.

"Does it hurt, Mama?" Alp asks. I spit the handkerchief from my mouth, a honeydew voice flows through my tongue – we're the angels, not the murdered ones.

The blond children play on the riverbank. The girl looks out from behind her brother, half-smiles, and ducks. Peek-a-boo, I see you. Wind caresses. A sickle moon waits in the sky. Barn swallows offer up pitifully glad songs.

I blink and walk out into air. Giver, let me live.

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AWARD HISTORY

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